FUNDING VEHICLES FOR SHARED EQUITY HOUSING

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Illinois, like the rest of the country, faces a housing crisis. In Illinois, 47% of renters are rent-burdened, and home prices are three times higher than the median household income (Federal Home Loan Bank of Chicago, 2026, pp. 15, 18). If you do not own a home, it is extremely hard to get one. A major cause of high housing prices is a lack of supply: there is a nationwide shortage of 7.3 million rental and 3.8 million owner-occupied units. Cities across the country must build more (Federal Home Loan Bank of Chicago, 2026, pp. 15,16). However, more market-rate housing is not enough. Research shows that in some metro areas with rapid housing growth, rent growth was higher for low-income households (McRae, Sheppard, & Roy, 2026, p. 5). New single-family homes were largely built for moderate- and high-income households (McRae, Sheppard, & Roy, 2026, p. 5). As we increase housing supply, we must ensure it is affordable for current residents and future generations. Shared-Equity Housing is one way to build a more equitable system.

Policy Background

What is Shared-Equity Housing?

Shared Equity Housing (SEH) is a form of legal ownership for communal property. Generally, it refers to models of owner-occupied housing that remain affordable in perpetuity (Thaden, 2018). These models often prioritize low-income households and view housing as a personal asset and a human right. SEH models are a crucial tool for addressing the housing crisis because they remain affordable in perpetuity and can reuse one-time acquisition grants and subsidies to provide permanent affordable housing (Thaden, 2018). Various models exist, but the most effective are Community Land Trusts and Limited Equity Cooperatives.

Community Land Trusts (CLTs) are nonprofit organizations that buy, own, and manage land for community benefit (Axel-Lute, 2021). The primary goal of CLTs is to ensure that housing is permanently affordable, and holding land in Trust is the main method of achieving this. Once the CLT acquires land, it will not be resold on the market: CLTs separate land ownership from building ownership (Axel-Lute, 2021). When someone wants to buy a home from a CLT, they only pay the development costs of the house, not the land. This structure enables CLTs to sell homes at a below-market price, and depending on the location, this can lower the price of a home by 20–50 percent (Axel-Lute, 2021)

Limited Equity Cooperatives (LECs) are multi-unit buildings completely owned and managed by residents. Like traditional cooperative buildings, residents purchase a "share" in the building, which entitles them to a unit and a vote in the building's governance (Ortiz, 2017). In addition to their mortgage payments, they also pay a monthly fee that covers shared building expenses (Ortiz, 2017). LECs are dedicated to low-income households. Historically, these are formed when tenants purchase their neglected building and rehabilitate it themselves (Ortiz, 2017). Sometimes, LECs are built on CLT land, creating affordable multi-unit housing (Ortiz, 2017).

Why are shared-equity models significant to solving the housing crisis?

SEH models stay perpetually affordable through resale restrictions. The SEH organization will sell the unit to the homeowner at a below-market price, and in exchange, the homeowner must sell it at a below-market price (Thaden, 2018). All individual shared-equity projects approach resale restrictions differently, but they all allow homeowners to gain some equity in the home upon resale. A common approach is to have a resale formula: the homeowner can sell it at the price they bought it for, add the costs of any additions, subtract the cost of physical depreciation, and then add a speculative equity increase (Wang et al., 2023, pp. 41-42). Some CLTs link this equity increase to Median Area Income: if the median income rose by 20% since you bought the unit, you can sell it for 120% of what you paid (Wang et al., 2023, p. 41).

These resale restrictions are one of the biggest advantages SEH projects have over traditional affordable housing projects. The Low-Income Housing Tax Credit (LIHTC) is the most popular way affordable housing projects are subsidized in the United States (ShelterForce, 2023). LIHTC's affordability requirements expire after 30 years; after that, affordable units within the project can revert to market-rate rents, effectively making them single-use (ShelterForce, 2023). SEH models allow a single acquisition subsidy or grant to be reused, ensuring permanent affordable housing without regular public funding. SEH projects are a better financial deal: in Chicago, a survey of affordable developers showed per-unit costs ranging between $521,000 to nearly $900,000. Local CLTs reported subsidy needs ranging from $172,000 to $284,000 per unit (Institute for Housing Studies, 2024, p. 8).

Policy Problem

SEH is an innovative tool that can provide a permanent solution to the housing crisis. However, their potential effectiveness is hindered by their small numbers: there are only 32 LECs and 13 active CLTs in Illinois (Institute for Housing Studies, 2024, p. 10) (Urban Homesteading Assistance Board National). The organizations that incubate SEH projects are affordable housing developers. They not only face the same problems as mainstream affordable developers but also encounter unique issues stemming from their shared-ownership model. My policy focuses on just one of these problems: **Shared-Equity Housing projects in Illinois lack a sufficient, affordable, and accessible funding source to expand their housing operations.**

Evidence

Table 1: Evidence Matrix

Evidence Category	Source and Year	Key Findings	Relevance
Research Report	Institute for Housing Studies. (2024). Community Land Trust Task Force Report . Chicago: Institute for Housing Studies at DePaul University .	The lack of consistent funding is one of the biggest problems facing CLTs in Illinois, and government funding is a recommended solution.	Interviews with leaders from active land trusts in Illinois
Organizational Census	Wang, R., Wandio, C., Bennett, A., Spicer, J., Corugedo, S., & Thaden, E. (2023). The 2022 Census of Community Land Trusts and Shared Equity Entities in the United States: Prevalence, Practice and Impact. Lincoln Institute of Land Policy.	Construction and rehabilitation are the most common ways CLT/SEH developer get more housing.	Current information on how active CLTs across the US manage their operations
Policy Brief	Neri, J. (2025, February). Leveraging the Community First Fund to Scale FHLBanks' Mission Impact.	The Community First Fund is a flexible and affordable source of funding for CDFIs.	Provides insight on the current and potential of the Community First Fund
Loan Product Brief	Federal Home Loan Bank of Chicago. (n.d.). Community First Fund.	The Community First Fund is a $50 million revolving loan fund that provides direct support to CDFIs in Illinois and Wisconsin.	Provides an overview of the Community First Fund's benefits and operations.
Government Program Documentation	Chicago Department of Housing. (2023, November 14). Request for Proposals: Shared Equity Investment Program.	The Shared Equity Investment Program is a Chicago DOH fund that invests in SEH purchase assistance and SEH acquisition support.	Details out the requirements, regulations, and funding sources of Chicago's SEH grant program.
Legislation	Mah, T., & Jimenez, L. (2025, January 7). Illinois House Bill 3291	Proposed legislation that would have reserved funds for limited-equity cooperatives.	Model legislation for a proposed policy alternative.
Investigative Journalism	Abello, O. P. (2026, January 6). Wholesale Banks: An Idea Whose Time Has Come Again?	Wholesale banks are a crucial source of capital for mission-oriented lenders who work with housing cooperatives.	A flexible, sustainable loan fund is valuable for lenders and SEH projects.
Policy Brief	Deursen, H.V. (2025, May 28). *Affordable Housing Finance 101*. Retrieved from Shelterforce: https://shelterforce.org/2025/05/28/affordable-housing-finance-101/	Affordable Housing Projects require a mix of grants, subsidies, and private loans to cover their development needs. Affordable sources of capital are vital tools for affordable developers.	Provides an overview of how affordable housing projects are financed.

The Evidence Matrix lists the sources that articulated the scope of the policy problem and identified potential solutions. The primary sources used come from researchers and journalists who interviewed leaders of active shared-equity developers. The people working in these organizations have direct experience with the problems facing development. They also have insight into how to solve them. These sources include: The Community Land Trust Task Force Report from the Institute of Housing Studies at DePaul; The 2022 CLT/Shared Equity Census from the Lincoln Institute of Land Policy; and housing journalists and researchers at Next City and ShelterForce. The additional sources on the matrix provided models for policy solutions, insight into existing programs, and quantitative data on the housing crisis.

The Current State of Shared-Equity Housing Development

The gathered evidence indicates SEH developers rely on new housing to expand their portfolios. Nationwide, 66% of new shared-equity housing comes from direct construction, and 62% comes from rehabilitation (Wang et al., 2023, pp. 52-53). The next most popular method is a partnership with another non-profit developer or property owner, accounting for 43% of new housing (Wang et al., 2023, pp. 52-53). Physical donations from individuals, corporations, and public land holders are the next most popular, and only 27% of SEH organizations partner with for-profit developers to acquire new housing (Wang et al., 2023, pp. 52-53).

These projects rely on external funding for their operations and projects: the majority have only 20% of their budgets covered by internal revenue (Wang et al., 2023, p. 56). The major external funding sources are individual donations, local government funding, state funding, and corporate donations (Wang et al., 2023, p. 56). When these projects receive federal funding, it is on an *ad hoc* basis. Projects have received federal funding via Community Development Block Grants, COVID-era Paycheck Protection Program loans, and Economic Injury Disaster Loans (Wang et al., 2023, p. 56).

There is government funding infrastructure dedicated to SEH projects in Illinois, but it operates through the Chicago City government. The Shared Equity Investment Program is a grant partnership between the Department of Housing, the Chicago Community Loan Fund, and the Resurrection Project. (Chicago Department of Housing). It provides acquisition support to SEH Projects, supporting low-income households, and purchasing support for low-income households purchasing units in existing SEH projects (Chicago Department of Housing, 2023, pp. 2-3). It is a 3.5-million-dollar grant fund sourced from Chicago Recovery Plan bond proceeds, with a maximum subsidy of $100 thousand per unit (Chicago Department of Housing, 2023, p. 5). While this program is better than nothing, it also highlights the problems with the current SEH funding environment.

The Current Funding Environment

The existing funding environment relies on grants, subsidies, and market-rate loans that may be inaccessible for SEH developers. Existing grants and subsidies are hard to obtain. There is no centralized funding source, and developers seek funding through government grants, subsidy programs, and philanthropic organizations (Institute for Housing Studies, 2024, p. 11). This administrative complexity requires developers to hire dedicated staff to apply for funding and manage the application process, raising labor costs (Institute for Housing Studies, 2024, p. 11). SEH organizations compete with traditional affordable developers for these limited funds. This process takes a long time, putting these developers at a disadvantage in high-demand real estate markets: market-rate developers can gather capital in days while affordable developers need months (Deursen, 2025).

Grant and subsidy funding have rules that may be incompatible with SEH projects. The LIHTC program is designed for large-scale rental units, not for owner-occupied units. While some SEH developers may find use for this, the average SEH portfolio is at least 80% single-family detached homes (Wang et al., 2023, pp. 59-60). The Chicago Shared Equity Investment Program has considerable spending restrictions. Grant funds cannot be used for construction and rehabilitation, which is the most common way SEH developers acquire new housing (Chicago Department of Housing, 2023, p. 5). Even when projects do receive funds, they do not cover all the necessary development costs: every affordable housing project requires private loans (Deursen, 2025).

Market-rate loans are too expensive, and conventional lenders are hesitant to loan to these projects. Shared property ownership complicates collateral for traditional loans. Lenders may not know how they will be repaid if the developer defaults on the loan (Abello, 2025). Even if the SEH developers are clear on how defaults would work, a private lender may associate non-traditional ownership with higher lending risk, either rejecting the loan or requiring a higher interest rate (Abello, 2025). Interest rates affect the total loan amount: loans with higher interest rates are more expensive than those with lower interest rates (Deursen, 2025). A higher interest rate increases the overall cost of housing, contradicting the goal of affordable housing. There are mission-oriented lenders knowledgeable about the SEH model who offer affordable loans. However, these lenders tend to have less source capital and can only provide small loans (Abello, 2026). This leaves a funding gap that SEH developers will have to fill with additional funding.

Policy Alternatives

This report suggests three policies that create public funding vehicles for SEH projects.

Policy Alternative #1: Dedicated Trust Funding

The Illinois Affordable Housing Trust Fund is a source of capital created by the Illinois Affordable Housing Act and managed by the Illinois Housing Development Authority. It is dedicated to supporting affordable housing projects serving households earning less than 80% of the area median income and is primarily funded by real estate transfer tax proceeds (National Low Income Housing Coalition, 2023). The fund currently has ~$60 million available and delivers these funds via grants and low-interest loans (National Low Income Housing Coalition, 2023). Trust funding can be used for both purchasing and acquisition support, and for construction and rehabilitation (Illinois Housing Development Authority, p. 360.203).

This policy alternative calls for legislation that reserves a percentage of the Fund for SEH projects. This policy has model legislation: had it passed, House Bill 3291 would have dedicated 1% of Trust Fund money to support limited equity co-ops (Mah & Jimenez, 2025). This policy alternative would expand the criteria to include SEH models. It would also advocate for a higher percentage of funds to be reserved: 1% of the current fund would amount to only $600,000.

Policy Alternative #2: Adjustments to the Shared Equity Investment Program

Policy 2 calls for adjusting the Shared Equity Investment Program. The reach of this program must be expanded statewide to help develop projects outside of Chicago. The program desperately needs additional funding. Only $3.5 million has been invested in the program, and the maximum subsidy is $100,000 per unit (Chicago Department of Housing, 2023, p. 5). This is not enough funding to effectively scale affordable housing. At its maximum, it can only fund the acquisition of 35 new SEH units, and it is unlikely it can provide that, as the program also funds purchasing support (Chicago Department of Housing, 2023, pp. 2-3).

The program also needs reliable revenue from state and local governments. It is currently funded by Chicago Recovery Plan Bonds, a one-time federal source of funding (Chicago Department of Housing, 2023, p. 7). It is doubtful that the current presidential administration will provide federal funds for such a housing project. Perhaps most importantly, funding restrictions must be changed so SEH projects can use the money for construction and rehabilitation.

Policy Alternative #3: State Investment in the Community First Fund

Policy 3 recommends State investment in the Federal Home Loan Bank of Chicago's Community First Fund. The Federal Home Loan Bank (FHLB) is a bank with a dedicated mission to support affordable housing projects (Neri, 2025, p. 1). Despite its name, the FHLB is a government-sponsored entity independent of the federal government. As a wholesale, cooperative bank, it provides low-interest financing only to member financial institutions (Federal Home Loan Bank of Chicago). Individual people cannot open accounts or receive funding; it is where banks go to get a loan. There are 11 branches that cover the United States, and the FHLB of Chicago supports members in Illinois and Wisconsin (Federal Home Loan Bank of Chicago).

The Chicago branch has a unique program called the Community First Fund (CFF): a 50-million-dollar revolving loan fund that makes direct, noncollateralized, low-interest, long-term loans to member community development financial institutions (CDFIs) (Federal Home Loan Bank of Chicago, n.d.) (Neri, 2025, pp. 2-3). CDFIs use this money to make flexible, affordable loans to economic development projects. The FHLB does not dictate how funds are used, as long as the CDFI is dedicated to the same community development goals as the CFF (Neri, 2025, p. 2). The unique structure of this fund enables CDFIs to finance economic development projects that other lenders cannot. The Chicago Community Loan Fund, the CDFI that works in the Shared Equity Investment Program, is a member of the FHLB of Chicago and has access to this fund (Federal Home Loan Bank of Chicago).

This policy suggests a partnership between the State of Illinois, the FHLB of Chicago, and the member CDFIs with access to the Community First Fund. The CFF already loans to lenders with a history of working with SEH models. The CFF is a mission-oriented lender that can provide funds at a below-market rate, offer longer-term loans than other lenders, and does not require the same type of loan collateral as private banks. The State can contribute money to this fund in exchange for influence over how funds are spent, thereby ensuring additional focus on SEH projects.

Selecting Evaluative Criteria

The evidence shows SEH developers require a funding vehicle that is compatible with the shared-equity model, available at below-market interest rates, and has enough total capital to effectively scale SEH projects. In addition, a funding source must have a reliable revenue source so developers can plan future projects. If the funding vehicle utilizes public funds, it must have buy-in from relevant political stakeholders. There are five criteria for determining whether the proposed policy alternatives are successful.

Accessible: Is the funding source knowledgeable of the SEH model and administratively simple to receive?

Sufficient: Is there enough total capital to help projects meet their development needs?

Affordable: Is the funding available at below-market rates?

Renewable: Is the funding self-sustaining?

Politically Feasible: Is the funding reliant on the cooperation of multiple political stakeholders?

Projecting Outcomes and Confronting Trade-Offs

The Outcome Matrix weighs each policy alternative against these criteria.

Policy Alternative	Accessible	Affordable	Sufficient	Renewable	Politically Feasible	Score
Baseline	**Low: -1** Complex application, unknowledgeable lenders.	**High: +1** Grants do not need to be repaid.	**Low: -1** Grants do not cover enough costs.	**Low: -1** Grants are one-time payments.	**Neutral** Changing nothing requires no political will, in this case.	**-2**
Dedicated Trust Funding	**Medium: 0** Construction and Rehab are eligible uses, but unknowledgeable lenders.	**High: +1** Grants do not need to be repaid; loans are zero and low interest.	**Low: -1** Low source of total capital in Trust, reserved capital is low.	**High: +1** The Trust is funded by a portion the State Real Estate Transfer tax.	**Medium: 0** Requires new legislation; amends current funding structure.	**1**
S.E.I. Program Adjustments	**High: +1** This program is adjusted to work with the SEH developers.	**High: +1** Grants do not need to be repaid.	**Low: -1** The current funding is low; sufficiency relies on additional funding.	**Low: -1** Grants are one-time payments.	**Low: -1** Creating a new revenue source for a new state program; requires major statewide investment.	**-1**
State Investment in CFF	**High: +1** Existing loan infrastructure with knowledgeable lenders.	**High: +1** Loans at a below-market rate.	**High: +1** State funds would add to existing capital.	**High: +1** Funding source is a revolving loan fund.	**Low: -1** Requires a new organization structure outside of Illinois' complete authority.	**3**

Table 2: Outcome Matrix

Policy Outcomes and Trade-Offs Discussion

The baseline policy is the weakest option. The current funding environment relies on decentralized, non-renewable grants that do not adequately cover development costs. The existing grants are incompatible with the SEH model and prevent SEH developers from effectively expanding their housing portfolios. Keeping the baseline model is politically neutral: in this case, changing nothing requires no political will.

The Illinois Affordable Housing Trust offers grants and affordable loans funded by a real estate transfer tax. While this provides an affordable and renewable funding source, the Trust has only $60 million in total. Since this policy advocates for a percentage of these funds, it is insufficient to scale housing projects. Construction and rehabilitation are eligible uses of funds, but it is unclear whether the Trust can provide funding that aligns with the SEH model. They may be willing to work with SEH developers: Nicki Pecori Fioretti, the IDHA's Director of Community Affairs, was the Chair of the Illinois CLT Task Force (Institute for Housing Studies, 2024, p. 3), but there is no indication that hard policy changes will come out of the Task Force's findings. This policy will require some political will: while it is an amendment to an existing program, it still requires dedicated funding through legislation. The last legislation recommending a similar policy failed to pass.

Adjustments to the Shared Equity Investment Program would provide grant funds to lenders familiar with SEH projects and, if construction and rehabilitation are considered eligible grant uses, would be compatible with the SEH model. However, the available capital is extremely low and relies on a one-time federal funding source. To be successful, a new statewide Shared Equity Investment Program would require significant public funding and a dedicated public revenue source; establishing such a program will be a political battle.

State investment in the Community First Funds leverages existing infrastructure and supports lenders experienced with the shared-equity model. As a mission-oriented loan fund, it is financially self-sustaining and offers below-market-rate loans. The unique structure also offers non-collateral loans that meet the needs of non-traditional housing developers. Although only $50 million is currently available, further state investment could expand capital to support shared-equity projects. However, establishing this new partnership among multiple stakeholders will require significant political effort. The CFF is a unique program within the FHLB system, and it is unclear whether the State of Illinois has entered a similar partnership before. This policy also requires the State to influence the Fund, thereby compromising part of the FHLB's government independence.

Additionally, there are some trade-offs to consider when implementing *any* of these policies. Shared equity projects primarily focus on owner-occupied housing. Funding for these projects could remove funding from affordable rental projects. Even if these serve low-income households, people need housing, even if they are unable or not ready to purchase a home. There are other bottlenecks slowing housing development, such as zoning regulations and a lack of available land. If this money is set aside for SEH projects and those projects can't be built, it can't be used for other community development projects. There are consequences to being successful: an effective funding source may become a source of competition. A state-subsidized source of below-market loans could receive political resistance from for-profit lenders.

Policy Recommendation and Implementation Concerns

Given these considerations, the recommended policy alternative is State Investment in the Community First Fund. This unique revolving loan fund is designed to provide affordable, long-term loans to non-traditional economic development projects. The CFF has been in operation for over ten years (Federal Home Loan Bank of Chicago, n.d.), and the State does not need to build existing loan infrastructure from scratch. The structure of the FHLB means that State investment into the fund empowers local CDFIs rather than competing with them. There is $50 million already available: the funding capital is not entirely dependent on the State. As a loan fund, the money is more sustainable than grants.

The most pressing concerns when implementing this policy are about its political feasibility. The investment will require public funds, and dedicating funds from the State budget will be a political struggle. The State will need a way to ensure that shared-equity projects receive high consideration. The terms of investment must include some influence, such as an advisory board. This policy depends on the cooperation of the Federal Home Loan Bank of Chicago and is independent of the State. There is no leverage to hold over the FHLB if it does not agree to the partnership. Also, the FHLB of Chicago serves Illinois and Wisconsin, and there is a chance that Illinois funds will be used for projects in another state. The State should lobby Wisconsin to make a similar investment, but that requires another political project.

Illinois' SEH developers face structural barriers that prevent them from scaling the permanently affordable housing their communities urgently need. Innovative public-sector intervention can deliver sufficient funding that is accessible, renewable, affordable, and aligned with the shared-equity model. Despite the potential political pushback, the housing crisis is too urgent to be solved by incremental adjustments to the status quo. Meeting this moment will require public sector innovation that is bold enough to overcome political resistance and forward-thinking enough to create durable systems of affordable homeownership. Even if difficult, this type of innovation is essential to ensure that Illinois can build, preserve, and protect housing that remains affordable for generations.

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